MODULE 16

Keeping the Truck Loaded

Ace Dispatch · Dispatcher Training Course

Module 16 of 18 · Closing & Mastery · about a 15-minute read

A parked truck and an empty truck have one thing in common: they both cost money and earn nothing. The truck payment, the insurance, the driver — those bills come due whether the trailer is full or empty, rolling or sitting in a lot. The *only* thing that pays them is loaded miles.

So here's the math that actually runs a carrier: every empty mile and every idle day is pure loss. The rookie dispatcher waits until a load delivers and *then* starts hunting for the next one — and the truck sits overnight, or deadheads a hundred miles to the next pickup, bleeding money the whole way.

> *The pro is always thinking one move ahead: the next load is lined up before the wheels even stop on this one. That single habit — keeping the truck loaded — does more than almost anything else to separate a carrier that makes money from one that just stays busy going broke.*

WHAT YOU'LL BE ABLE TO DO

Keep a truck earning instead of sitting: you'll know why empty miles quietly kill profit and how to minimize them, you'll line up the next load before the current one even delivers, and you'll think the way good dispatchers think — in lanes and markets, headhaul versus backhaul — so the truck flows from one paying load to the next. This is the skill that turns a dispatcher into a profit center.

1 Utilization Is the Whole Game

Start with how a carrier actually makes money, because it reframes your entire job. A carrier's biggest costs are *fixed* — the truck payment, insurance, and the driver get paid about the same whether that truck runs ten thousand miles this month or two thousand. Those costs don't shrink when the truck is empty or parked. The only thing on the other side of the ledger is **loaded miles** — miles with paying freight on the trailer.

So the dispatcher's north star is simple: keep the truck loaded and moving, as close to all the time as you can. You've got two enemies. One is **empty miles** — driving with nothing on the trailer. The other is **idle time** — the truck sitting between loads. Beat those two down, and the same truck and the same driver suddenly turn a profit. That's why a great dispatcher treats an empty truck almost like an emergency.

The truck that sits or runs empty	The truck that flows
Fixed bills keep coming — **earning $0**	Load → short deadhead → load — **always earning**
Deadheads 100+ empty miles to the next pickup	Next load picked up **near where the last one dropped**
Sits overnight in a lot, "what's next?"	Next load was lined up **yesterday, in transit**
Same truck & driver — quietly losing money	Same truck & driver — turning a profit

2 Deadhead: the Silent Profit-Killer

The first enemy has a name you already know: **deadhead** — the empty miles a truck runs to *get* to a pickup, from the load-board lesson. Now look at it as money. When Marcus drives empty to reach his next load, he's burning fuel and hours with zero revenue coming in. Those miles cost real money; they just don't pay any.

That means deadhead has to factor into *every* "what's next" decision. The goal isn't zero deadhead — that's impossible, freight isn't always sitting right where you drop. The goal is to *minimize* it, and to judge a load by what it really nets. A load that pays great but sits two hundred empty miles away can easily net *less* than a decent load twenty miles away, once you count the fuel and the hours to deadhead to it. The tool for this is the **effective rate** from the load-board lesson — the rate spread across *all* the miles, empty and loaded. A dispatcher who only looks at the headline rate and ignores the deadhead to reach it is fooling themselves. Judge the whole picture.

3 Headhaul vs Backhaul: the Direction of Freight

Freight isn't balanced. It flows harder in some directions than others, and that gives you two words you'll use constantly.

A **headhaul** is the strong direction — a lane loaded with freight and good rates, usually heading toward where demand is high. On a headhaul, finding a well-paying load is easy. A **backhaul** is the return, the weaker direction — coming back from somewhere that doesn't generate much outbound freight, where rates are lower and loads are scarce. The classic trap: you take a great load *into* an area, and then discover there's almost nothing to haul *out* of it, so the load home is cheap or you're stuck deadheading back.

▲ **HEADHAUL — THE STRONG DIRECTION**

Origin →→→ High-demand market

Plentiful freight, **good rates** — a well-paying load is easy to find.

▼ **BACKHAUL — THE WEAK RETURN**

Low-outbound area → Home

Scarce freight, **lower rates** — or nothing at all, leaving you to deadhead back.

Think about the backhaul before you commit to the headhaul. A fantastic load into a dead market can lose money overall if you can't get a paying load back out.

So the pros plan the round trip, not just the load in front of them, and they "chase headhauls" — they position the truck toward strong freight markets so the *next* load is an easy, well-paid one instead of a desperate scramble. You're not just booking a load; you're deciding where the truck will be sitting when it's empty again.

4 Always a Move Ahead: Line Up the Next Load Before Delivery

Now the timing habit that ties it together — and it's mostly about *when* you look, not just where. Don't wait for the load to deliver to start searching. While the current load is rolling and you're running your check calls, you're *already* scanning the board for the next load out of the delivery area, timed to the moment the truck goes empty.

In transit
load A rolling
DO THIS NOW — On a **check call**, you're already scanning the board for the next load out of the delivery city.

You know
two things
Exactly **when & where** load A delivers (you set the **appointment**), and the driver's **hours** (can he start fresh, or need a reset?).

Delivery
load A done
Load B booked to start **right around where & when A ends** — short hop or no empty miles at all.

Done well, it's a clean handoff: deliver load A, a short hop or no empty miles at all, pick up load B. The truck never sits in a lot wondering what's next — because you already answered that question yesterday.

5 Think in Lanes and Markets

The top layer is learning to see the map the way an experienced dispatcher does. Freight moves in **lanes** — origin-to-destination pairs — and markets aren't equal: some areas pump out tons of outbound freight (easy to reload), and some are "black holes" that are hard to get a paying load out of. Over time you learn which is which, and you use it. You favor delivering into areas you can reload from, and you sequence loads so the truck keeps earning and works its way home.

And you balance all of it against two more realities: the **driver** wants to get home on a reasonable schedule, and the **equipment** has to match whatever you book next. So the real game isn't just "what's the next load" — it's "what *sequence* of loads keeps this truck earning, fits the driver's hours and home time, and lands him back where he started ready to do it again."

6 Tri-Hauls: Loop the Truck Home Loaded

Here's the sharpest version of lane-and-market thinking, and it's how you turn one good day into a great one. An out-and-back runs the truck somewhere, then drags it home — and the way home is usually the weak direction. A **tri-haul** — also called **triangulation** — fixes that. Instead of out-and-back, you route three loaded legs that loop the truck home: A→B→C→A. Every leg carries paying freight. Nothing runs empty.

▲ TRI-HAUL — THREE LOADED LEGS LOOP HOME

A · Dallas → B · Memphis

Leg 1 loaded — **Dallas→Memphis**, paying freight on the trailer.

▲ THE MIDDLE STOP BENDS TOWARD HOME

B · Memphis → C/A · Atlanta

Leg 2 loaded — **Memphis→Atlanta**, and Marcus lands back home ready to do it again.

The blended rate beats any single leg. Average the dollars across the whole loop — all three legs over all the miles — and it climbs above any one leg, because there's no dead return dragging it down.

Why does that beat an out-and-back? Because every leg earns. When you average the money across the whole loop — the **blended rate**, the dollars from all three legs spread over all the miles — it climbs above any single leg, because there's no dead return dragging it down. One leg might pay a little under your floor; the loop as a whole still wins, because the truck never gave away a free mile going home.

How do you spot one? Look for a third corner that pays its own way and bends the truck toward home. A strong freight market makes a good corner — there's always a load out of it. A black hole makes a bad one — you'll get stuck. So you're hunting for that middle stop that earns *and* points the nose home.

Concrete version with Summit: Marcus delivers in Dallas. Instead of grabbing the straight shot back to Atlanta, you build a triangle — he loads Dallas→Memphis, delivers, then loads Memphis→Atlanta, three loaded legs that loop him home. Each leg pays. And this is the RPM lesson coming full circle: you're not chasing one load's rate, you're maximizing the *dollars across multiple loads* — every leg earning, the truck flowing toward home, the whole loop pushing you toward your daily and weekly goal instead of one fat headline rate that strands you.

7 Consistency Beats Chaos: Build Repeat Lanes

One more layer, and it's the one that quietly makes the job easier every week. The board is chaos — different broker, different rate, different fight, every single day. The way out is to turn good one-off loads into **repeat lanes**: the same broker, the same run, that you re-win at the rate you want. The through-line here is simple — **consistency beats chaos.**

You earn those lanes by doing what you said you'd do. The truck shows up on time. The driver is clean and professional at the dock. You answer your check calls. The paperwork comes back right, every time. Do that, and a broker stops treating your truck like one of fifty on the board — they call *you* first when freight comes up, before it ever posts. That first call is worth real money: you're not fighting ten other carriers for it.

And it lets you hold your rate. A broker will pay a little more for a truck they trust than for the cheapest one on the board, because a reliable truck doesn't fall off, doesn't sit, doesn't blow the appointment. Reliable is worth more than cheap. Push a consistent lane far enough and it stops being a board game at all — it becomes a **contract rate**, the locked-in lane and price we talked about earlier. A contract rate is just a consistent lane, formalized. That's the goal: fewer fights, steadier money, lanes you own.

So the real game isn't just "what's the next load" — it's a sequence of loads that keeps the truck earning, loops it home, and gets re-won week after week. That's the chess of dispatching, and keeping the truck loaded is how you win it.

Walkthrough — Keeping Summit's Truck Earning After Dallas

Plan the reload while the anchor load is still in transit (delivered Dallas Thursday 1:00 PM; Summit is Atlanta-based).

THE SETUP — DON'T WAIT FOR DELIVERY

On **Wednesday**, while Marcus is rolling and on a check call, you're already working the next load out of Dallas, timed for Thursday afternoon.

DIRECTION	The truck needs to head back toward home — Atlanta. **Dallas→Atlanta is the backhaul,** but it's a real lane, not a dead market.
FIND IT	A Dallas→Atlanta load, ~780 mi, pickup Thursday afternoon near the Dallas receiver → minimal deadhead from drop to next pickup.
JUDGE IT	Reload pays **~$2,400 (~$3.08/mi loaded)** with a short deadhead → strong effective rate. Rookie outcome: deadhead ~780 mi home **empty** = a full day and a tank of fuel earning $0.
CHECK HOURS	Can Marcus legally deliver at 1:00, then pick up that afternoon and roll? If not, time the pickup for Friday morning around his reset.

Execute with the booking skills you already have (board → doable? → vet → book → negotiate → appointments → rate con). Marcus delivers, hops a short deadhead, loads Dallas→Atlanta, and **earns his way home** instead of running empty.

See the difference one day of foresight makes: the rookie's truck sits in Dallas Thursday night and crawls home empty Friday — a day and ~780 miles of pure loss. Yours delivers, reloads, and gets *paid* to go home. Same truck, same driver, same week — the only difference is that you planned the backhaul before the headhaul was even finished.

Module 16 Glossary — your quick reference

The utilization toolkit — what keeps a truck earning instead of sitting.

The direction of freight

Headhaul — The strong direction — a lane full of freight and good rates, heading toward high demand. A well-paying load is easy to find.

Backhaul — The weaker return direction — scarce, lower-paying freight coming back from a low-outbound area. Plan it *before* you commit to the headhaul.

Triangulation (triangle route) — A three-stop loop (A→B→C→A) that keeps every leg loaded and lands the truck back home — instead of a straight out-and-back that deadheads the return.

The cost of empty

Deadhead — Empty miles run to reach a pickup — real cost, zero revenue. Minimize it, and judge a load by its effective rate across all miles. (From the language & load-board lessons.)

Idle time — The truck sitting between loads — fixed bills still due, nothing earned. The other enemy of utilization alongside empty miles.

Check yourself

Try these from memory first, then check your answers below.

1. **Why does keeping the truck loaded matter so much to a carrier?**
2. **What's the difference between a headhaul and a backhaul, and why think about the backhaul first?**
3. **One load pays great but is 200 empty miles away; a decent load is 20 miles away. How do you decide?**
4. **When should you start looking for the next load?**
5. **What does "thinking in lanes and markets" mean?**

ANSWERS

1. A carrier's costs (truck, insurance, driver) are mostly fixed and don't drop when the truck is empty or idle; only loaded miles earn. Empty miles and idle time are pure loss, so utilization drives profit.

2. Headhaul = the strong direction with plentiful freight and good rates; backhaul = the weak return with scarce, cheaper freight. Think the round trip first — a great headhaul into a dead market loses money if you can't get a paying load back out.

3. Compare the effective rate across all miles (deadhead included) — the far load's empty fuel and hours may net less than the close one. Minimize deadhead; judge the whole picture, not the headline rate.

4. Before the current one delivers — while it's in transit — timed to when and where the truck goes empty, and gated by the driver's available hours. Book it to start near where this one ends so the gap and deadhead are small.

5. Knowing which areas are easy to reload out of (strong markets) vs hard (black holes), and sequencing loads — sometimes a triangle instead of an out-and-back — to keep every leg loaded, fit the driver's hours and home time, and land the truck back ready to go again.

WHAT'S NEXT → MODULE 17: THE DISPATCHER'S DAILY ROUTINE

You've now followed a load from the very first phone call all the way to a reconciled payment — and learned to keep that truck rolling, load after load, instead of letting it sit. But a real dispatcher isn't running one truck through one load at a time. They're juggling several trucks at once, a dozen moving pieces, a phone that won't stop, and a day that never quite goes to plan. So next, we put the whole job together into the rhythm that holds it all up: the dispatcher's daily routine.

YOUR COMPANY'S PLAYBOOK

This lesson teaches utilization as a generic skill. Your own operation adds its specifics — its load-planning workflow (when and how dispatchers line up the next load, and the loaded-mile percentage or deadhead targets it holds to); its strong lanes and preferred markets, and the known black-hole areas to avoid delivering into without a reload plan; its tools and broker relationships for finding reloads fast; how it balances utilization against driver home time and hours; and its escalation when a truck is about to sit empty. *Your trainer or supervisor will fill these in.*